

Merz stays on after state election defeats

送信者: EG Europe 受信日時: 2026-09-21 17:29

【メール原文】

Merz's position as chairman of the CDU and chancellor has stabilized temporarily after his CDU took two heavy electoral blows in state elections on 20|||||||

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Merz temporarily safe after repeat CDU election defeats

21 Sep 2026 04:27 EDT [Discover more on the Portal](#)

Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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Friedrich Merz will stay on as chancellor despite the painful losses of his Christian Democrats (CDU) in two state elections on 20 September, and has tied his future to the implementation of key national reforms.

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In Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania, the CDU failed to clear the 5% threshold for the first time in post-war history, while the far-right AfD came out strongest at 38.2%, but remains with no path to power.

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In Berlin, a rejuvenated Left Party scored a strong victory, while the Social Democrats (SPD) came in last in their traditional stronghold, likely leading to a Left-led government after complicated government formation.

Merz's position as chairman of the CDU and chancellor has stabilized temporarily after his CDU took two heavy electoral blows in state elections on 20 September. A CDU-Internal leadership challenge that seemed imminent over the last few weeks fell apart over his opponents' hesitation, but will likely recur in the spring of 2027. The coalition's – and Merz's – short- to medium-term survival now hinges on the implementation of the July pension reform package. This compromise had initially stabilized the government, but is now at risk of unraveling over opposition to the abolition of an early retirement scheme. Merz stubbornly defended the package, effectively tying his political future to its implementation. Eurasia Group believes that the package will eventually pass, likely after a compromise on early retirement. Keeping the introduction of private investment elements in the package will be the CDU's key objective.

In a historic first, the CDU failed to re-enter the state parliament in Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania, sending shock waves through the party that had already scored a catastrophic loss two weeks earlier in Saxony-Anhalt. Local SPD prime minister Manuela Schwesig, whose party came in second, will very likely lead a coalition government with the Left Party and the Greens, putting herself in a strong position to compete in next year's competition over the SPD's national chairmanship. The AfD, after more than doubling its result, will remain without a path to power after being shunned by all other parties in

parliament.

In Berlin, the CDU prime minister will be ousted after a strong showing of the Left Party, the rejuvenated former East German state party that ran on a hard-left platform and will likely lead a left-leaning coalition government with the Greens and SPD. The SPD was relegated to the fifth-strongest party in a town it had dominated politically until 2023. The CDU came in second, ahead of the AfD, but won't be strong enough to defend its hold on the premiership. A key watchpoint will be housing, where the Left Party favors expropriating private housing companies.

Both AfD and the Left favor a softer foreign policy stance vis-à-vis Russia but will fail to derail strong German support for Ukraine. Both elections on 20 September took place in Germany's east, where a "peace" course vis-à-vis Russia is considerably more popular than in the West. While the AfD demands the lifting of all sanctions on Russia, the reinstatement of the North Stream 2 gas pipeline, and the end to all support for Ukraine, its influence on German foreign policy will remain marginal. A key watchpoint will be the firmness of the SPD at the national level, a party that has remained firm on Russia so far but has a pre-war track record of leniency vis-à-vis Russia. The Left Party will face considerable scrutiny over the openly anti-Semitic leanings of large parts of its far-left electorate.

The Greens will likely be part of both new state governments, handing them strong leverage in negotiations within Germany's federal system. Governments with Green participation will likely gain 35 votes in Germany's upper house of parliament, the Bundesrat. This will endow the Greens with a strong negotiating position in national politics despite being in opposition. The Bundesrat, representing Germany's 16 states in federal law-making, has veto powers on considerable parts of the legislative agenda, especially on fiscal and tax issues, but not on foreign policy.

Germany's party landscape continues its fast-moving realignment away from traditional centrists to more radical parties on the right and left. The trend is fueled by a deeply rooted economic crisis that threatens Germany's industrial base, strong polarization over migration policy, and the unsettling effect of the Ukraine war and the military build-up following Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine. It is further exacerbated by a targeted Russian disinformation and fake news campaign as part of Moscow's escalating hybrid war against the West, in which Germany is a primary target.

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